FICTION ▼

A TRAIN CHUGS THROUGH IT

Rahul Bhattacharya's* Railsong *is the coming-of-age story of a woman and a nation, interwoven with the world of the Indian Railways



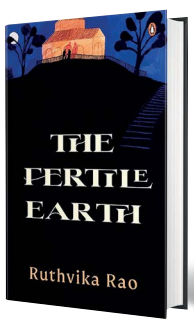
ARUN KUMAR

RAILSONG
By Rahul Bhattacharya
BLOOMSBURY
₹799; 416 pages

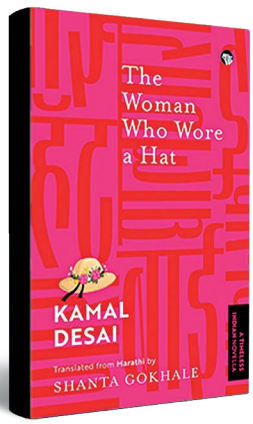
Before he began work on his second novel, Rahul Bhattacharya knew this much: it would feature an individual, and that individual would be located in a "vast enterprise that gestured at Indian complexity and scale". "But I didn't have anything beyond that," he says on a video call. "I didn't have a time period, I didn't have a tone. I didn't even have the enterprise I would be looking at. And, most crucially, I didn't have the character. That process of discovery became the entire novel."

That novel, *Railsong*, is writer and editor Bhattacharya's third book, a compelling, often funny bildungsroman of a woman and a nation in the making, set largely in the world of the Indian Railways.

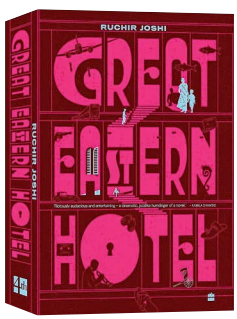
The novel is anchored by Charulata Chitol, a motherless girl who grows up in a fictional railway township in the 1960s before making a life in Bombay and later joining the public sector undertaking herself. "I find the railways fascinating, both as something to travel by, and as a bureaucratic entity and a labour force. With its employees drawn from all classes, all castes and all regions, it gives us a pretty representative idea of Indian life."



THE FERTILE EARTH
By Ruthvika Rao
PENGUIN
₹699; 384 pages



THE WOMAN WHO WORE A HAT
By Kamal Desai
Translated by Shanta Gokhale
SPEAKING TIGER
₹399; 128 pages



GREAT EASTERN HOTEL
By Ruchir Joshi
HARPERCOLLINS/ FOURTH ESTATE
₹1,499; 920 pages

RIVER OF STORIES

WRITER AND TRANSLATOR ARUNAVA SINHA PICKS HIS FAVOURITE FICTION READS OF THE YEAR GONE BY

If fiction is the art of making the unexpected feel extraordinary, more than one book—or three—by Indian writers lived up to that expectation. Ruchir Joshi's *Great Eastern Hotel* pushes back resolutely against short attention spans with effervescent prose and a vast storyline that takes Calcutta out of the aftermath of World War II and projects it on our mental screens